Equally, if not more disturbing are important findings from 2006 showing the spread of narcotics cultivation from 165,000 hectares to 193,000; more land than is under coca cultivation than in Latin America. And while some key provinces in the north and center are being reported as opium free, some key figures in those provinces continue to profit handsomely from drug trafficking.

Extensive receipts from this activity—''drug money''—weakens key institutions and fuels and strengthens the Taliban, while at the same time corrupting the country's governmental leadership.

There are serious disputes about how best to deal with the drug economy. Some want large scale, aerial eradication with the potential for serious, disruptive impacts on rural Afghans and their livelihood. Others are counseling more gradual but more complete approaches seeking to find crop substitutes and other supports for the 90 percent of Afghans who have said they are willing to abandon poppy cultivation if they can count on earning half as much from legal activities.

Closely linked, but also independently important for Afghanistan's future, are questions of development and reconstruction. It is the second lowest country on the UN's Human Development Index for 2007–08. Life expectancy is short, infant mortality high and access to clean water and health services severely limited. Nevertheless, there are some positive economic indicators—8.7% growth (against a small base), low inflation, a stable currency against the dollar and significant foreign exchange reserves. Refugees are returning, agricultural output is up and roads are being repaired and rebuilt to the rural areas.

The lack of security has disrupted trade, communications, transport and the energy infrastructure.

Even after six years, foreign assistance amounts are hard to tabulate and coordination is weak. School populations have boomed particularly among girls and efforts are being made to fund primary health care. While some experts say it is an exaggeration, claims that only 10% of assistance gets to Afghans are worthy of attention and correction of the faults in these programs is badly needed.

Finally, Afghanistan can no longer be considered as an isolated state to be dealt with on its own. It is vulnerable as never before to external pressure and what goes on, especially in the Pakistan border region, is critical to success or failure. Kabul needs better relations with its neighbors, especially coordination with Pakistan and a commitment on the part of Pakistan to deal with its own tribal areas in the Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) region, something that is particularly challenging and elusive and has been over the history of modern Pakistan.

With all of these difficulties there is clear reason why we call attention to the need to improve and make more strategic and effective our support for Afghanistan. It is a state poised for a slide. Our ability to provide the help and support needed to make a difference remains a key factor. And for that purpose, I want to provide from our report a key list of major recommendations. The report itself should be consulted for the full list which is put together with the objective of forming a coherent and collective whole.

These recommendations are divided into three overarching recommendations and six groups—international coordination, security, governance and the rule of law, counter-narcotics, economic development and reconstruction and Afghanistan and its neighbors.

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